

As California's Wine Industry Struggles, Some Lodi Grape Growers Pivot to New Crops

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In Lodi, a Central Valley city historically defined by wine grapes, agricultural families are exploring new crops as the wine industry faces unprecedented challenges. The Mohr-Fry Ranch, a six-generation farming operation, exemplifies this shift.

Mohrgan Fry, the family's sixth-generation farmer, acknowledges the changing landscape: "Where the industry is at, you have to be able to diversify and be willing to try something new."

Industry challenges

California's wine sector faces multiple headwinds. Global wine consumption is declining, according to the International Organisation of Vine and Wine. Younger consumers are drinking less due to health and financial concerns, while baby boomers are reducing intake with age. Additionally, California growers compete against cheaper foreign-grown grapes, pressuring local producers.

The impact is severe: approximately 10% of vines in the Lodi area were removed in the past year alone, with about one-fifth of California's vineyard acreage ripped out since 2022.

Diversification strategy

Rather than abandon farming entirely, operations like Mohr-Fry are transitioning to alternative permanent crops. The family recently replanted former vineyard land with safflower as a transitional crop before converting to olives, leveraging the Ag Burn Alternatives Grant Program for financial support.

"Diversification is always good from an economic and business perspective," noted Stuart Spencer, executive director of the Lodi Winegrape Commission.

Legislative hope

Growers are watching AB 1585, which would require wines labeled "American" to contain 100% U.S. grapes, hoping it will encourage wineries to purchase from domestic producers rather than cheaper foreign sources.

Despite challenges, industry members remain cautiously optimistic about Lodi's continued agricultural relevance.